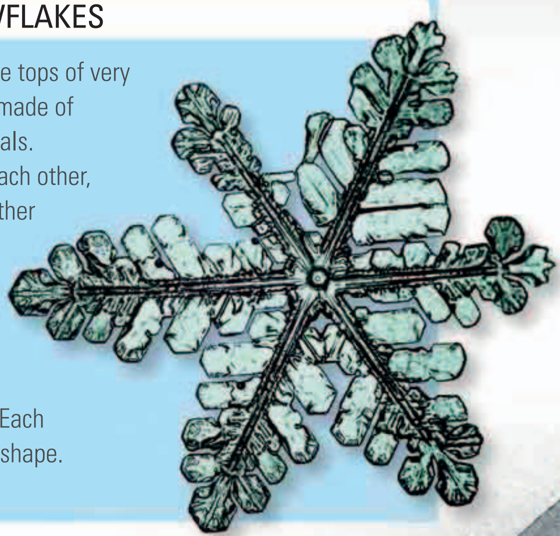
SIX-SIDED SNOWFLAKES

High-level cirrus clouds and the tops of very tall cumulonimbus clouds are made of microscopic six-sided ice crystals. The crystals are attracted to each other, and may become welded together as snowflakes. The crystals join together to create bigger and bigger six-sided structures, and this creates the snowflake's beautiful hexagonal (sixfold) symmetry. Each snowflake has its own unique shape.



SNOW AND SLEET

In very cold weather, lacy snowflakes fall as showers of powder snow. In warmer temperatures close to 32°F (0°C), snowflakes join up to form big, fluffy clumps of "wet snow." In even warmer conditions, the snow may partially melt as it falls, creating a mixture of snow and rain called sleet.

BLIZZARDS AND SNOWDRIFTS

High winds can pick up fallen snow and carry it in a blizzard. This is most common in very cold conditions where the snow is loose powder. When the snow-laden wind passes over or around an obstruction, the snow builds up in deep snowdrifts.

▸ SNOWDRIFT
Wind-blown snow has created a snowdrift alongside this car. The snow has settled on the side that is sheltered from the wind.